



BatonIndex

Leadership Succession Intelligence

A RESEARCH BRIEF FOR SEARCH PROFESSIONALS

Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership

How gender shapes who reaches the business-school deanship, and where the pipeline still stalls.

795

dean appointments

152

Carnegie R1 universities

1990-2025

36 years

Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership

Women now make up nearly a third of new business-school dean appointments, a remarkable rise from almost none a generation ago. But the aggregate hides where the gains land and where they stall. Drawing on BatonIndex's web-verified census of **795 dean appointments at all 152 Carnegie R1 universities (1990-2025)**, this brief traces how gender shapes access to the deanship discipline by discipline, and what that means for building a credible, diverse slate.

Six findings

- **Women's share of the deanship rose from 1.2% to 31.4%** across the eras, the office is steadily less male.
- **Discipline gates access.** Female dean share ranges from 28% in strategy to just 6.5% in operations.
- **Some fields clear the bar, others don't.** Finance (1.33) and strategy (1.18) convert senior women into deans above parity; operations (0.38) least of any field.
- **The shortfall starts upstream.** Women thin at every faculty rank before the dean pool, a leaky pipeline, not a dean-stage event.
- **An interim trap.** Women, and women in operations most of all, are over-channeled into interim seats.
- **Momentum is real but fragile.** 2026 brought the first permanent women operations deans, including Darden's first woman dean in seventy years.

HOW TO USE THIS BRIEF

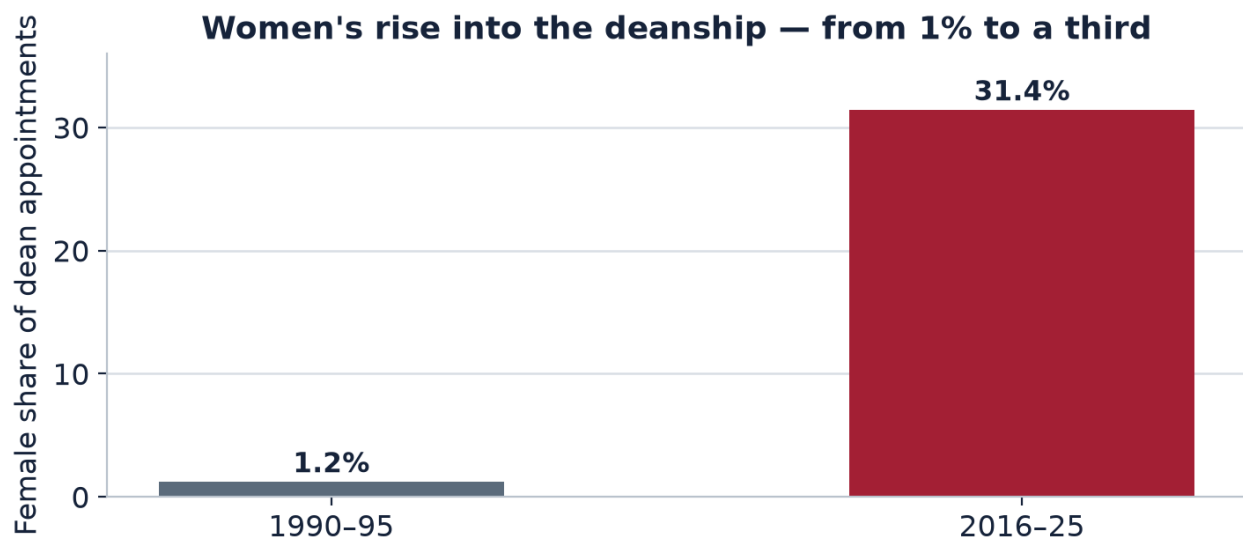
Each finding pairs the evidence with an implication for the search room, where the female pool is deep, where it thins, and how to read a slate that looks diverse on the surface.

The rise

Women's rise into the deanship

A generation ago the business-school deanship was almost entirely male. It no longer is. Across the census eras the female share of appointments climbed steadily from **1.2% in 1990-95 to 31.4% in 2016-25**, roughly one in three new deans today.

That secular gain is real and worth stating plainly. The findings that follow are not a rebuttal of it; they are a map of where the progress is concentrated and where it has yet to reach.



Female share of R1 business-school dean appointments, first era vs. most recent.

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The candidate field is far broader, and more female, than it was a decade ago. Pipelines and comps built on the old market will understate the qualified women now in play; refresh both before advising a client on who is realistically available.

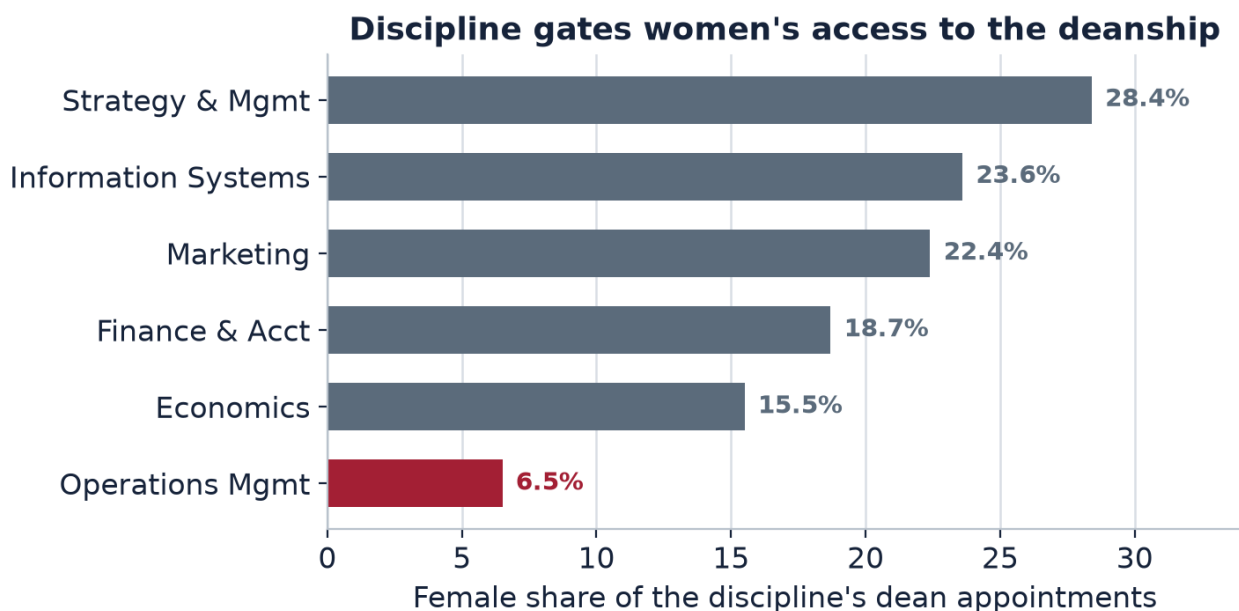
FINDING 2 OF 6

Discipline & access

Discipline gates women's access to the deanship

The path to the deanship runs through a discipline, and women's odds vary sharply by which one. Female representation among deans ranges from **28.4% in strategy and management down to just 6.5% in operations**, with information systems, marketing, finance, and economics arrayed in between.

This is not primarily about the dean stage, it reflects how many senior women each field carries and how readily it advances them. Where a candidate trained shapes whether a woman is even in the pool.



Female share of dean appointments by discipline. R1 census, 1990-2025.

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Female depth is a discipline question before it is a slate question. If a client wants a diverse field and the search is anchored in a thin-supply discipline, scope that reality up front, and widen the disciplinary lens early rather than defending a short slate later.

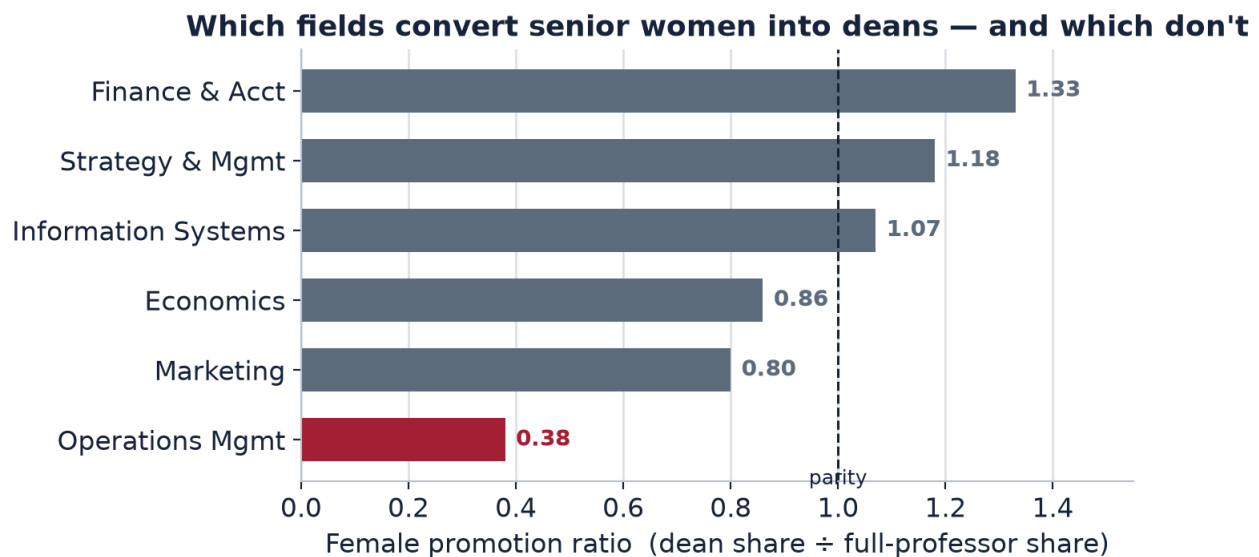
FINDING 3 OF 6

The pipeline test

Some fields clear the bar, others don't

Raw shares can mislead, because disciplines differ in how many senior women they have to promote. The sharper test benchmarks each field's female dean share against its own female full-professor pool. On that test, **finance and accounting (1.33) and strategy (1.18) convert senior women into deans above parity**, while **operations, at 0.38, is the lowest of any discipline**, and the only field that fails a test against its own supply of senior women.

The gap, in other words, is not uniform. Several fields are doing better than their bench would predict; one is doing markedly worse.



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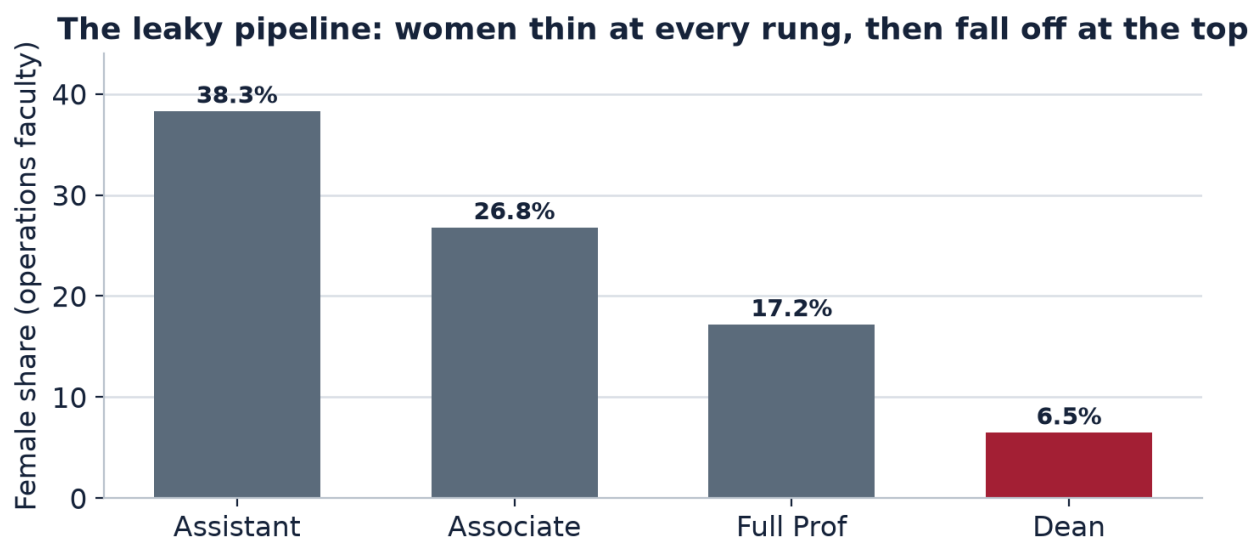
Use the parity read, not the raw count, to judge whether a discipline's pipeline is healthy. A field above parity is a place to source female candidates with confidence; one well below it is where an over-set bar may be quietly screening qualified women out.

The leaky pipeline

The shortfall starts upstream

The dean-stage gap is the end of a longer story. Tracking women's share by faculty rank shows the classic leaky-pipeline shape: **38% of assistant professors, 27% of associates, 17% of full professors**, and then just 6.5% of deans in operations. Attrition compounds at each rung, and most of it happens well before the dean search begins.

For a search professional this reframes the problem: by the time a committee convenes, the pool has already been narrowed by everything upstream of it.



Female share by academic rank (operations faculty), through to the deanship.

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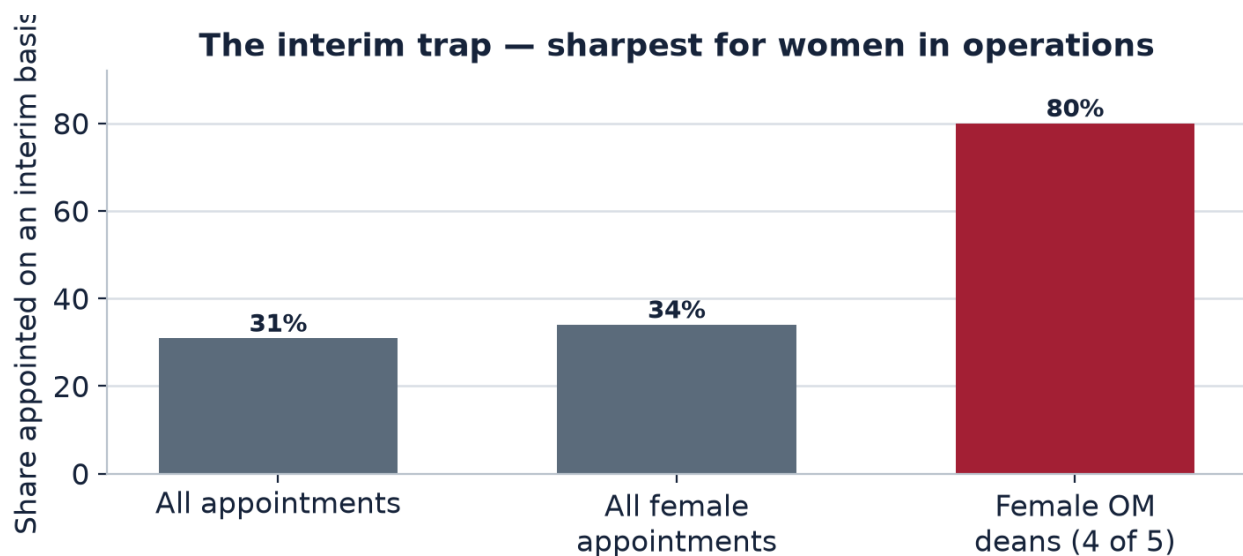
The lever most within reach is the associate-dean and full-professor feeder, not the final slate. Advise clients to track that feeder by gender between searches, the future dean pool is being set there, not in the two months a committee is active.

The interim trap

Women are over-channeled into interim seats

Not all appointments carry the same authority. Interim roles are time-limited, lower-authority, and increasingly fail to convert, and women are disproportionately routed into them. **34% of all female appointments are interim, and in operations four of the five women ever appointed served on an interim basis** (an 80% interim rate against a 31% average).

The pattern matters because aggregate 'share of women in leadership' dashboards count these seats equally, quietly overstating how much real authority has shifted.



Interim share of appointments: all appointments vs. all female vs. female operations deans.

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When a woman is put forward for an interim or caretaker seat, read the framing carefully. Push for a permanent mandate or an explicit conversion path so a strong candidate isn't parked in a role that quietly caps her trajectory, and discount headline diversity numbers that lean on interim appointments.

Signs of change

Momentum is real, but fragile

The most recent record carries genuine movement. In 2026 two schools appointed women trained in operations, historically the field most closed to them, to **permanent** deanships: **Amy Zeng at Chapman** and **Yael Grushka-Cockayne at UVA Darden**, **that school's first woman dean in seventy years**. They are the first such appointments in the record that are permanent leadership rather than interim stewardship.

The research literature is consistent that pipelines can be reshaped, but on a ten-to-fifteen-year horizon and through deliberate structural effort, not on their own. Two or three appointments are a signal, not a trend, the direction is set by what committees and their advisors do by default over the next several cycles.

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The firms and committees that put qualified women on the initial slate by default, especially in the thin-supply disciplines, are the ones that will shape the next decade's leadership. Momentum this early is influenced, not just observed.

What this means for your next search

Six evidence-based moves for committees and recruiters:

- **Refresh the market read.** The female field is far broader than a decade ago, don't advise off stale supply assumptions.
- **Scope female depth by discipline.** It ranges from 28% to 6.5%; set expectations before promising a diverse slate.
- **Judge pipelines by parity, not raw counts.** Some fields over-perform their bench; one badly under-performs.
- **Work the feeder, not just the slate.** The shortfall is set upstream at the associate-to-full transition.
- **Guard against the interim trap.** Secure permanent mandates or conversion paths; discount interim-heavy diversity numbers.
- **Default qualified women onto the slate.** Early momentum is shaped by what advisors do now, not later.

About this brief

This brief draws on the same authoritative dataset as its companion, *The Discipline Behind the Dean*: a hand-coded, web-verified census of **795 dean appointments at all 152 Carnegie R1 universities, 1990-2025**, with each dean's discipline and gender classified individually from primary sources. The gender analysis, female shares by discipline and rank, promotion ratios against each field's own senior-faculty pool, and interim patterns, is drawn directly from the paper's reported statistics. Full-professor benchmarks come from AACSB demographic surveys and the field's own faculty census.

BatonIndex maintains leadership-succession intelligence on more than 10,000 academic leaders across twelve role families, business, medical, law, nursing, pharmacy, education, agriculture, public health, arts & sciences deans, provosts, and presidents, with sourced education histories, career pathways, and live appointment tracking. This brief is one view into that data.

PUT THE DATA TO WORK

Want the underlying benchmarks for a specific school, discipline, or region, or a co-branded edition for a client? Reach the BatonIndex team through the Contact link in the app.

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